a Buddhist could worship Hindu deities, and just as a monotheist could believe in the existence of Satan, so the typical American nowadays is simultaneously a nationalist (she believes in the existence of an American nation with a special role to play in history), a capitalist (she believes that open competition and the pursuit of self-interest are the best ways to create a prosperous society), and a liberal (she believes that humans have certain inalienable rights). Nationalism will be discussed in Chapter 18. Capitalism – the most successful of the modern religions – gets a whole chapter, Chapter 16, which expounds its principal beliefs and rituals. In the remaining pages of this chapter I will discuss liberalism, which upholds the sanctity of human liberty.

Whereas theism believes that gods are the ultimate source of all meaning and authority, and nationalism thinks it is the nation that provides us with meaning and authority, liberalism puts its faith in individual human beings. Allegedly, nature has bequeathed to humans very special feelings, which give meaning to the entire world, and nature has also endowed humans with a free will, which should be the ultimate source of all authority. Accordingly, liberalism argues that individuals should have the liberty to do whatever feels right to them – provided they do not harm the liberties and feelings of others.

This sounds very abstract and complicated, so let’s give a few examples of what liberalism means in practice. Consider politics. In politics, liberalism believes that there is no higher authority than the feelings and free choices of the citizens. Whereas in medieval Europe kings ruled by the grace of God, in modern democracies when the time comes to appoint a government, the choice isn’t made by God or by those claiming to represent Him on Earth. Rather, each and every citizen is asked for their views on the matter, and there is no higher authority that can thwart the will of the people. The voter knows best. Even the elected government cannot place itself above the voters. It continues to be answerable to them, and must not violate their basic liberties.

An analogous attitude dominates liberal ethics. When we need to evaluate the morality of a certain act, liberalism tells us that we need not listen to God or to scripture or even to the government. Rather, we need to examine human feelings. They are the supreme moral authority. For liberals, morality doesn’t mean obedience to a god, to a holy book, or to state laws. Rather, liberal morality means liberation from suffering. For